

THE PHILOSOPHICAL STUDY OF NATURE CONNECTS THE PRESENT WITH THE PAST

THE DISTRIBUTION OF SPECIES OVER SPACE AND TIME

IN CONTEXT

KEY FIGURE

Alexander von Humboldt (1769–1859)

BEFORE

1750 Swedish botanist Carl Linnaeus explains that the distribution of plants is determined by climate.

AFTER

1831–36 Charles Darwin makes various observations on the voyage of HMS *Beagle*, confirming that many animals living in one area are not found in similar habitats elsewhere.

1874 British zoologist Philip Sclater produces a description of the zoogeography (the geographical distribution of animals) of the world's birds.

1876 Alfred Russel Wallace publishes his two-volume book *The Geographical Distribution of Animals*, which becomes the definitive biogeography text for the next 80 years.

The distribution, or range, of biological communities and species varies according to many factors—including latitude, climate, elevation, habitat, isolation, and the species' characteristics. The study of species distribution